Tennis Rules at a Glance

Scoring, serving, play and etiquette for singles and doubles

1. The Basics

Tennis is played between two players (singles) or two teams of two (doubles) on a rectangular court divided by a net. Players hit the ball over the net with a racquet, and a point is won when the opponent cannot return the ball legally. A match is made up of points, which form games, which form sets.

- **Court size:** 78 ft (23.77 m) long. 27 ft (8.23 m) wide for singles, 36 ft (10.97 m) wide for doubles.
- **Net height:** 3 ft 6 in (1.07 m) at the posts and 3 ft (0.914 m) at the centre.
- **Match format:** usually best of three sets, or best of five at some men's Grand Slam events.

2. Scoring

Points in a game are called **Love** (0), **15**, **30** and **40**. The server's score is always called first.

- **Game:** first to win 4 points, with a lead of at least 2 points. At 40-40 (**deuce**), a player must win two points in a row. The next point gives **advantage**; if the player with advantage loses the following point, play returns to deuce.
- **Set:** first to win 6 games, with a lead of at least 2 games (6-4 or better). At 6-6 a **tiebreak** is normally played.
- **Tiebreak:** first to 7 points with a 2-point lead. The player due to serve serves the first point, then players alternate every **two** points. Players switch ends after every 6 points.
- **Match:** first to win 2 sets (best of three) or 3 sets (best of five). Final-set rules differ between tournaments, and some use a 10-point match tiebreak instead of a full final set.

3. The Serve

- The server stands behind the baseline, between the imaginary extensions of the centre mark and the sideline, and must not step on or over the baseline before contact.
- The ball is tossed and struck **before it bounces**. The first point of every game is served from the **right** (deuce) court, then players alternate sides.
- The serve must travel diagonally over the net and land inside the opposite **service box**. Hitting the net cord is a **let** if the ball still lands in the correct box, and the serve is retaken without penalty.
- The server gets **two attempts**. Failing both is a **double fault** and loses the point.
- A serve is a **fault** if it lands outside the service box, or if the server foot-faults, misses the ball when swinging at it, or the ball touches a permanent fixture before bouncing.
- The server alternates after every game; in doubles, partners take turns serving.

4. Winning and Losing a Point

A player **loses** a point if any of these happens:

- The ball bounces twice on their side of the court before it is returned.
- They hit the ball out of bounds, or into the net.
- They hit the ball before it has crossed the net, or reach over the net to play it.
- They, their racquet, or their clothing touches the net or the opponent's court while the ball is in play.
- They deliberately carry or catch the ball on the racquet, hit it twice, or throw the racquet at the ball.
- The ball hits them or anything they wear or carry (other than the racquet in hand).

5. Lines and In-Play Rules

- **A ball touching any part of a line is in.** This applies to the baseline, sidelines and service lines. Only a ball landing completely outside is out.
- In singles, the outer (doubles) alley is out of bounds. In doubles it is in play, but the serve must still land in the correct service box.
- A ball that hits the net and drops over is **good** during a rally.
- A player may reach over the net to hit a ball only after it has bounced on their side and blown back, and must not touch the net while doing so.
- A **let** is called when a point must be replayed, for example if a ball from another court enters play or an outside interruption occurs.

6. Changing Ends and Breaks

- **Change of ends:** after the 1st game, then after every odd-numbered game (1, 3, 5...) and at the end of a set if the total number of games is odd.
- **Between points:** play continues at a steady pace. Many tournaments enforce a **25-second** shot clock between points.
- **Changeover break:** up to 90 seconds at changeovers, and 120 seconds between sets.
- **Warm-up:** typically 5 minutes before the match.

7. Doubles Rules

- Each team decides which partner serves first in each set, and the order must be kept for the whole set. Receiving order is likewise fixed for the set.
- Partners may stand anywhere on their own side, and either partner may play any ball. The ball must be hit alternately by the two opposing teams, not necessarily by the same partner.
- If a serve hits the receiver's partner, the server wins the point.

8. Equipment and Conduct

- **Ball:** 6.54 to 6.86 cm in diameter, yellow or white. **Racquet:** strings must be flat and the frame no longer than 29 inches (73.7 cm).
- Players may **not** receive coaching during play unless the event allows it. Medical timeouts and toilet breaks are regulated by the tournament.
- **Code violations** such as racquet abuse, audible obscenities, ball abuse or unsportsmanlike conduct usually lead to a warning, then a point penalty, then a game penalty, and finally default.
- **Hindrance:** a deliberate distraction (such as shouting during a rally) loses the point; an unintentional one means the point is replayed.

9. Officials and Line Calls

- The **chair umpire** has the final say on questions of fact and enforces the rules. At most events **line judges** or electronic line calling make calls on the lines.
- Without officials, players call the lines on their own side of the net. A player in doubt must give the benefit of the doubt to the opponent and call the ball **good**.
- A call of **out** must be made promptly. Calls made late are not valid. Many professional events allow a set number of video challenges per set.

10. Etiquette

- Stay quiet during points and avoid walking behind a court during a rally.
- Call the score clearly before each serve, and ask for a ball to be returned politely.
- Return stray balls from other courts only between points, and say **"ball on court"** or call a let if one rolls onto your court during a rally.
- Shake hands with your opponent at the net at the end of the match, and thank officials.